

Tools Used in Machine Learning

Before completing this lab, I understood that Python was used in machine learning, but I did not fully understand how the different Python tools worked together. I had some familiarity with programming and data, but this lab helped me see that machine learning is not just about creating a model. A large part of the process involves preparing, examining, understanding, and visualizing data before a model is ever built. Working with the Iris dataset gave me a simple way to see how these tools fit into the larger machine learning workflow.

One useful concept for me was working with pandas DataFrames. I found the DataFrame concept easy to relate to because it is similar to working with a spreadsheet, but it provides much more flexibility for programming and analyzing information. Instead of manually examining rows and columns, I could use Python to select information, calculate statistics, group records, and inspect the structure of the dataset. The `groupby()` allowed me to calculate the average measurements for each species. This helped me understand how programming can make data analysis repeatable instead of having to do calculations manually.

The Iris dataset also helped me understand the importance of knowing what the data actually contains. The dataset had 150 samples, four numerical features, and three different classes. Seeing this information in the DataFrame made the dataset much less abstract. I could see the individual measurements and understand that each row represented an observation while the columns represented different characteristics of the flowers. This proves that machine learning models depend on the quality and structure of the data given.

Working with NumPy, calculating the mean and standard deviation of the sepal lengths showed me how calculations can be performed efficiently on collections of data. The mean sepal length was 5.84 centimeters, while the standard deviation was 0.83 centimeters. Rather than calculating these values manually, NumPy allowed the calculation to be performed directly on the data. This helped me understand why numerical libraries are so important when working with larger datasets.

The visualization portion of the lab was probably the part that made the relationship between data analysis and machine learning make sense. When the sepal length and sepal width were displayed in a scatter plot, I could visually compare the three species. The setosa samples appeared more separated from the other species, while versicolor and virginica showed more similarities. Looking at the graph made patterns easier to recognize than they would have been by looking only at a table of numbers. This showed me that visualization is not simply about making a project look better. It can be an important analytical tool for discovering relationships and patterns in data.

Another lesson was the importance of checking my work instead of assuming that code is correct because it runs. The notebook included verification steps, such as checking that the mean and

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Derrick K. Gibbs-McGlaston
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standard deviation were numerical values. Running the entire notebook from beginning to end also helped demonstrate the importance of reproducibility. A machine learning project should be able to run consistently rather than depending on calculations or steps that are performed manually.

The lab also helped me understand how these tools connect to future machine learning work. Pandas can be used to organize and clean datasets, NumPy can perform numerical operations, matplotlib can help visualize patterns, and scikit-learn provides tools for building machine learning models. Understanding that relationship makes the next stages of the course easier to understand because I can see where data preparation and exploration fit before a model is trained.

One question I am interested in exploring further is which features provide the most useful information for distinguishing between different classes. The Iris dataset contains both sepal and petal measurements, and I would like to investigate whether some measurements are much more useful than others. I am also interested in seeing how the results of a visualization compare with the actual performance of a machine learning model.

This lab changed my understanding of machine learning tools from seeing them as separate Python libraries to seeing them as components of one workflow. I learned that understanding the data comes before trying to make predictions from it. Good machine learning begins with disciplined data analysis: knowing what the data contains, checking its quality, finding meaningful patterns, and using the right tools to understand it before moving on to modeling.